

SIR ARTHUR THOMAS COTTON (1803–99)

A British general and an eminent civil engineer of Madras, Sir Arthur Thomas Cotton was born in Cheshire, England, on 15 May 1803. He was a part of the Madras Engineers from the 1820s and was instrumental in the construction of many irrigation and navigation canals from 1828. His well-known projects include canals on the Rivers Cauvery, Coleroon, and Godavari. Apart from irrigation, Cotton was also a significant figure in the development of railways in India. In 1832, he proposed a line connecting Madras and Bombay. In a document dated 4 May 1836 to the Inspector General of Civil Estimates, he argued for the advantages of railways over canals. Cotton retired in 1860 and was knighted in 1861 for the development work he undertook in India. There is a museum built in his honour in Rajahmundry, Andhra Pradesh, and barrages constructed across River Godavari are named after him.



Connecting Red Hill

The construction of a short rail line southwest of Madras connected the Red Hills with Cochrane's Canal, and came to be known as the Red Hill Railway. The construction might have begun in 1836 but the line was certainly in operation by the middle of the 19th century. There is evidence from newspaper articles suggesting that the iron works industries in Cuddalore district in Tamil Nadu were fully operational for the construction of this railway. Reports also suggest that the line cost the Government Rs 50,000 and parts of it had wooden structures. The exact type of locomotive used on this line remains unknown. Author Simon Darvill suggests it could have been a wind-powered or animal-hauled carriage, or even a William Avery's rotary steam engine, or a version of it. Still, the project was short-lived and certainly non-functional by 1845.

In 1844, Sir AT Cotton continued his work on the Red Hill Railway while also supervising the construction of an irrigation dam on the Godavari Delta, and also built a railway line from the Quarry Hill to the Godavari bank to transport material. Tracks were made of broken and